



Fit/Behavioral Interview Questions

Before you set foot into any in-person or HireVue interview, you should do the following to prepare for “fit” questions:

1. **Draft Your “Story”** – This one is your answer to the “Walk me through your resume” or “Tell me about yourself” question. You need a short outline of 100 – 150 words and a full version that is 200 – 300 words.
2. **Outline Your 3 “Short Stories”** – You can use these to answer questions about your leadership skills, work experience, challenges, failures, etc. These stories should ideally come from your work experience, but it’s OK to use student/leadership activities if you’re a student.
3. **Select 3 Strengths and 3 Weaknesses** – Your strengths can be somewhat generic, but your weaknesses should be “real but not too serious,” i.e., you do not want to say anything that would destroy your chances of winning the job.
4. **Prepare for the Key Objections Bankers Will Raise About Your Background** – Compare yourself to the “Ideal Candidate” that bankers are seeking and see where you come up short.

We recommend this structure to answer the “Walk me through your resume” question:

1. **The “Beginning”** – Your initial background (hometown, university, or business school).
2. **Your Finance “Spark”** – The specific person, event, or experience that made you interested in finance or investment banking.
3. **Your Growing Interest** – How you gained more relevant skills and work experience over time that prepared you for this job.
4. **Why You’re Here Today and Your Future** – Why this firm and this group fit your long-term plans perfectly.

For your 3 short stories, we recommend picking a “**success story**,” a “**failure story**,” and a “**leadership story**” that you can re-use for many questions.



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For example, your success story could describe your search fund internship, where you helped the owner research many companies and eventually submit an LOI (Letter of Intent) to acquire a small business in the area.

Your failure story could relate to a student club you took over and tried to grow. Maybe you targeted 2x higher membership, but you didn't get close to that due to poor marketing, a weak team, or insufficient funding.

Your leadership story could relate to an internship task where you had to coordinate with other employees or interns to resolve a problem, such as a payment issue or a client emergency. **The key difference vs. the success story is that this one must involve working with others in a company or organization.**

The best **strengths** to cite include quantitative/analytical abilities, client management skills, the ability to work long hours, attention to detail, work ethic, team/leadership skills, and knowledge of accounting and finance.

Acceptable **weaknesses** might include an inability to delegate well in all situations, taking too long to make decisions, not always speaking up when you see a problem, or not giving useful feedback to teammates.

These are legitimate weaknesses – not fake ones like “I work too hard” – but they're not deal-breakers in the same way that poor math skills and attention to detail are.

Finally, for your “**real weaknesses**” or the objections that interviewers will raise about your background, remember that **most bankers are risk averse**.

They like candidates who attended top universities and business schools, earned high grades, completed highly relevant finance internships, have interesting hobbies/interests, and are personable.

So, anything in your profile that does *not* match this idealized banker could be a weakness: Lower grades or test scores, an unknown university, lack of accounting/finance knowledge, lack of relevant work experience, not enough hobbies/interests, no track record of working long hours, no other European languages if you're applying in London, etc.

To address these issues, you usually point to an “improvement trend” (e.g., for grades) or a “compensatory factor” (e.g., for lack of relevant work experience – point out how some of the skills from your work/leadership experience do, in fact, line up).

For more details on all these points, please see [the full fit/behavioral guide](#).

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The “Big 5” Fit Questions

The “Big 5” here refers not to an NCAA conference but to **the most important fit/behavioral questions** that will come up in all interviews.

Everything else should be easy if you have good answers to these questions.

And if you don’t have good answers, the rest of the interview will be a chore.

1. Walk me through your resume / Why are you here today? / Tell me about yourself.

Yes, these are all the same question. This is the single most important question in any interview and one you should spend at least 1 – 2 hours preparing for.

We explained the basic structure above, so here’s an example of how to draft a **short outline** if you’re a student with a “mixed” background, such as internships at a search fund and a Big 4 accounting firm but nothing specifically in IB:

- **The Beginning:** You were born in Thailand and attended university in the U.S. because you won a scholarship there; your father also had a real estate business.
- **Finance Spark:** You became very interested in sports franchises and the financing of sports teams in university due to some football player trades you followed, so you majored in Finance to learn the business side of the industry.
- **Growing Interest:** In your first 1.5 years of university, you completed Big 4 audit and search fund internships. You liked working on deals and valuing companies, and now you want to work on more complex transactions involving larger companies.
- **The Future and Why You’re Here Today:** You want to use your background in emerging markets and search funds to advise companies on cross-border and private equity-related deals.

Here’s an example of a full resume walkthrough that uses this outline:

“Sure. I was born in Thailand, came to the U.S., and went to Vanderbilt for university since I won a scholarship there. The school also had a good reputation for business and finance.

My father ran a real estate business in Thailand, so I learned about deals from a young age, but I became more interested in finance during my first year in university. There was controversy



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over one football player who quit and joined the Broncos early for a record-high salary, and the story made me interested in sports franchises and financing.

So, to learn more about the business side, I majored in Finance and completed an audit internship at Ernst & Young in Thailand. I liked the financial statement analysis, but I wanted to work on valuation and deals, so I returned to the U.S. and worked at a search fund in my second year.

The owner was interested in acquiring a local HVAC small business he could use as a roll-up platform in the region, so I screened for companies and performed quick valuations. The internship ended as he was submitting an LOI to acquire a \$10 million business, but I helped with the bid valuation and some due diligence for the deal.

I liked the search fund experience, but I want to work on larger deals in different industries, so I'm most interested in investment banking. I've also spoken with Vanderbilt alumni in banking and taught myself more technical skills since my internship ended.

I'm here today because I want to leverage my background in emerging markets and search fund deals to move into investment banking and work on larger, more complex deals. And your group has a great reputation for cross-border and private equity-related deals."

2. Why investment banking?

If you told your story properly (see above), bankers should not even ask this as a follow-up question – but sometimes they still ask to check for consistency in your answers.

This question is tricky because it has many **bad answers** (e.g., "You want to learn a lot," "You want the exit opportunities," or "You want to work in a high-stakes environment").

The only decent answer is that **you want to work on deals from start to finish**, and investment banking is the only field offering the experience in this depth and breadth (yes, PE/VC firms also work on deals, but they reject a huge percentage early on).

Say that you've already had some exposure to deals or investing, but your previous jobs/internships were missing elements X, Y, and Z (e.g., maybe you worked at a Big 4 firm and only advised on certain aspects of transactions, such as the purchase price allocation).

But you want to work on the entire process from start to finish and get more "reps" by working on many different deals over time.



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Show that your previous internships, activities, and jobs led you *part of the way* to IB but not the entire way there.

3. Why our bank?

You should mostly answer this question in your resume/CV walkthrough. But, again, you may get follow-up questions to clarify or check your consistency.

Your answer should demonstrate how you've **networked with bankers at this firm** and/or know something about their **recent deals and strategies**.

A decent answer might look like this:

"I'm interested in your bank because I've met quite a few people there already, including [Person Name 1], a VP in the New York office, and [Person Name 2], a Senior Associate in the San Francisco office, at an information session last month, and I've gotten along well with all of them. Also, I noticed you've been advising on many cross-border natural resources M&A deals lately, like [Company X]'s [\$Y billion] acquisition of [Company Z], and I'm really interested in that sector."

If you have not networked with anyone at the bank, look up a recent deal or news announcement and use that.

Avoid citing generic reasons like "the culture" or "more client interaction" because these could apply to *many different firms*, not just the one you're interviewing with.

4. What are your strengths and weaknesses?

You should present 2 – 3 strengths and 2 – 3 weaknesses and then give short examples (from your "short stories") to support them.

If you don't have one story that illustrates everything, you can use one story for your strengths and another for your weaknesses, but make them **CONCISE**.

Don't try explaining how you're improving or "fixing" your weaknesses because that will make your answer too long. You can address that in a follow-up question. Here's an example:

"My main strengths are my work ethic, ability to meet tight deadlines under pressure, and my quantitative skills."



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I used those strengths in my last corporate finance internship when I had to work with different departments to complete a quarterly report on a last-minute deadline when the more senior team members in my group were gone. I had to quickly make sense of unfamiliar reports and transactions and submit accurate work.

My weaknesses are that I sometimes take too long to make decisions, and I don't always speak up in group situations, even when I know something is going wrong.

In one recent M&A case study at business school, I could tell that one team member wasn't doing the required work, but I waited too long to approach him, and our team didn't place well as a result. We could have avoided problems if I had spoken up earlier."

5. Explain or justify your [Real Weakness.]

Since bankers are **risk averse**, you can expect to get direct questions about whatever seems like your most glaring weakness.

This question differs for each candidate, so we cover several examples in the [Flaws & Failures section](#).

For a simple example, let's say that you **graduated from university and worked for 2 years in another industry**, and now you're aiming for investment banking roles as a lateral hire.

Therefore, any interviewer is likely to ask you some variation of: "Why didn't you get into investment banking right out of undergrad?"

You **should not** admit that you tried to get in and failed. Instead, explain it by stating that:

- 1) You became interested very late in the process when it was too late to get the required sequence of internships (this works better if you went to a non-target school); OR
- 2) You knew about banking but thought you wanted to do consulting, corporate finance, Big 4 advisory, or something else until you began working full-time and changed your mind (less convincing).

The key is to show that you became interested in IB *over time* due to your post-university work experiences and that you followed a specific plan to get in. Here's an example:

"Sure. To clarify, I became interested in investment banking in my third year of university after transferring from a state school. But I didn't have the sequence of internships required to win an



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internship, and most of the large banks had already finished recruiting by then, so I decided to gain full-time experience and move in afterward.

I joined the Ernst & Young Transaction Advisory Services team to gain client and accounting/finance experience, and then I joined an independent valuation firm so I could spend more time on valuation and deal analysis.

Now, I want to move into investment banking and combine the skills I've gained in my previous work experience to work on the entire deal process from start to finish."

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Teamwork/Leadership

These questions should be simple if you've already prepared your 3 short stories: A "Success" story, a "Failure" story, and a "Leadership" story.

1. Can you talk about a team project or group activity you've worked on?

You should use your "Success" story and the STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result) structure for this one. Aim for 100 – 150 words to keep your answer under 60 seconds. Here's an example:

"Sure. During my summer internship at the New York State Comptroller's Office, I worked in a team of two attorneys, an investigator, and an Analyst to look into financial waste and misappropriated funds.

In one case, we investigated a public hospital and reports of misused government funds there. I researched and analyzed the hospital's financial reports and worked with the Analyst to sift through huge amounts of data.

The Analyst had very little time, and we were on a tight reporting deadline, so I had to work long hours and come in on weekends to finish the project.

I came up with a more efficient, automated way of interpreting the financial reports, and I found several cases of fund misuse by one division at the hospital. Based on that report, the Comptroller's Office withheld funds until the hospital changed its policies and replaced staff."

2. Can you describe a situation where a team did not work as intended?



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You can use your “Failure” story here. Use this question to state one of your weaknesses and explain how you’ve been improving:

“Sure. During college, I started a math tutoring business for high-school students. I won dozens of clients and wanted to expand the business by hiring more coaches.

I hired five coaches, but the business did not work out because it was too hard for me to do the tutoring while also training and managing others at the same time; it was also hard to motivate the new hires since most were doing it part-time.

I ended up canceling the expansion and just keeping a few of my own clients. I learned that it’s very difficult to do the work and manage others at the same time, so if I had to do this again, I would have a partner in charge of sales and management.”

3. Can you tell me about a time you faced an ethical dilemma in a team or with a co-worker?

You could use any of your short stories for this question but **focus** on a different aspect—disagreeing with a team member over the right actions.

You don’t have to cite a gigantic, dramatic dilemma; it could just be a bit dodgy but not outright illegal. Here’s an example:

“Sure. When I worked in a team of four in the JP Morgan M&A case study at my university last year, we had to pick a recent deal and recommend for or against it in a presentation.

One team member knew the winners from the previous year, and he suggested contacting them, getting their presentation, and using their entire structure but changing the deal and valuation to maximize our chances of winning.

I thought it was a bad idea that went against the rules of the competition, so I lobbied against it and convinced him to use an original structure; I even offered to draft the presentation and have the other team members pick a deal and value the company.

We ended up coming in second place, but I think we used the right approach.”

4. What was the most difficult situation you faced as a leader, and how did you respond?

This question is *almost* the same as the previous one, but you should use your “Leadership” story for this one and focus on the key challenge(s) you overcame.



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Spend more time describing that challenge and the ACTION you took rather than the Situation. Here's an example:

"In my first year of university, I acted as the team leader for a marketing project with five students. I had to make sure everyone finished their assigned tasks.

One week before the project was due, a team member called me to say that he had a family emergency, couldn't finish his tasks, and hadn't done anything yet. He had to go home immediately.

But he desperately needed to pass the class, and he asked me to pretend that he had done all the required work.

I gathered the other team members and convinced them to pull an all-nighter with me to finish as much of the assignment as we could. We didn't get the best grade, but everyone passed.

I 'covered' for the team member but decided not to work with him on projects in future classes."

5. Can you tell me about a time when you stepped up and demonstrated leadership even when you were not in an official leadership role?

You can use your 3 "short stories" to answer this question, but you should stick to the one where you did *not* hold an official title or leadership role.

Most likely, that means you'll use your "Success" story or "Failure" story. Here's an example:

"In my corporate finance internship last summer, I mostly supported my Manager and Analyst in the Treasury Department.

We had to finish end-of-quarter reports, and my Analyst was pulled into a company-wide offsite for several days while my Manager was away because of a family emergency.

I knew we would miss the reporting deadline for our Cash and liquidity positions, so I contacted all the other departments, introduced myself, explained the situation, and got all the required transactions and balances from them.

Then, I called the Analyst, explained the results so far, and had him and the Manager sign off on my work. They reviewed it when they came back and fixed a few issues, but we were able to meet the reporting deadline."

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Strengths & Weaknesses

All these questions should be easy if **you spent time selecting your 3 strengths and 3 weaknesses**, [as recommended above](#).

The main challenge is *adapting* your responses to the many variations they could ask.

Sometimes, you might have to combine your strengths and weaknesses with your three “short stories,” your main “story,” or your answers to other questions.

1. What are your strengths and weaknesses?

You should present 2 – 3 strengths and 2 – 3 weaknesses and then use one of your “short stories” to support them.

If you don’t have one story that illustrates everything, you can use one story for your strengths and another for your weaknesses, but make them **CONCISE**.

Don’t explain how you’re improving or “fixing” your weaknesses because it will be almost impossible to do all that in less than 150 words. Here’s an example:

“My main strengths are my work ethic, ability to meet tight deadlines under pressure, and my quantitative skills.

I used those strengths in my last corporate finance internship when I had to work with different departments to complete a quarterly report on a last-minute deadline when the more senior team members in my group were gone. I had to quickly make sense of unfamiliar reports and transactions and submit accurate work.

My weaknesses are that I sometimes take too long to make decisions, and I don’t always speak up in group situations, even when I know something is going wrong.

In one recent M&A case study at business school, I could tell that one team member wasn’t doing the required work, but I waited too long to approach him, and his part of the project ended up hurting our team’s score. We could have avoided problems if I had spoken up earlier.”

2. What’s your greatest strength?

For this question, pick one strength and use one of your “short stories” to support it. This is a “softball question” that tests your preparation more than anything else. Here’s an example:



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“My greatest strength is my communication ability. I work well with team members from different backgrounds, and I make sure everyone is on the same page so there are no misunderstandings.

For example, in my operational consulting internship, I worked in a 10-person marketing team, and the initial campaigns we produced weren’t great. No one wanted to blame the others, but I knew that several team members didn’t completely understand the tasks.

I spoke with everyone and figured out that several team members had science and engineering backgrounds and didn’t know much about marketing, so I explained the concepts to them and then divided up the work so that they could focus on the numbers and analysis instead.

The client ended up liking our campaigns and hiring the firm again.”

3. What’s your greatest weakness?

You could pick any of your weaknesses for this one, but the one that’s **least damaging** for the role is best.

For example, if you’re applying to intern or Analyst-level roles, **don’t** say you have trouble working long hours or understanding the financial statements. A weakness related to your leadership or management abilities is better.

Once you’ve picked the best weakness, back it up with one of your “short stories” and briefly explain how you’re working to improve it. Here’s an example:

“My greatest weakness is that I often take too long to make a decision, even when I know the correct choice.

For example, when I was running my math tutoring business in university, one of the tutors I hired received very ‘mixed’ feedback from students. Some loved his style, and some hated it.

He wasn’t hurting the business, but he also wasn’t a huge benefit, and he was difficult to deal with since he always asked for higher pay.

I knew I should have let him go within the first 2 – 3 months, but I waited 6 months to do it, which reduced the time I could spend on sales and limited our growth.

I’ve been working on this problem by forcing myself to make several decisions each week – even small ones – to get into the habit of acting more quickly.”



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4. What's your biggest failure?

You can use your "Failure" story here, but make sure it is a "real failure," or you'll look silly.

For example, don't say that earning a B+ in one class was your "biggest failure."

A more appropriate failure might be a job or internship that went poorly, a business or student club that failed to take off, or a disappointing study-abroad experience. Here's an example:

"My biggest failure was being forced to shut down my math tutoring business in university. I started the business because I received a lot of requests from other students for help with math assignments, and I had developed good teaching methods.

Initially, it went well, and I won a few dozen satisfied clients. But when I tried to expand the business by hiring more tutors, I struggled to maintain service quality.

I was spending so much that we began losing money, so I had to shut it down and go back to only a few of my clients.

I was disappointed, but I learned the difficulty of delivering a service while managing and training others at the same time. If I did it again, I would split up the roles and focus on one or the other."

5. What feedback did you receive from your most recent internship or job?

This one is a combined Strengths and Weaknesses question, and like all "combined" questions, it's tough to give supporting stories *and* explain how you're fixing your weaknesses.

You'll have to state something brief for the "fix" or possibly leave it out if you're using multiple stories in your answer.

You don't need to give all 3 strengths and all 3 weaknesses; it's better to give 1 or 2 so that you have a few "in reserve" in case the person wants more. Here's an example:

"On the last day of my private equity internship last year, my Principal said he admired my ability to work long hours, get up to speed quickly on valuation and financial modeling, and find interesting companies efficiently.

In one case, we got an inbound deal a few days before a bank's bidding deadline, and I had to research the medical imaging industry and figure out how to value the company and assess its competitors, so I stayed in the office over a holiday weekend to finish it.



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For areas to improve on, they said I wasn't always the best at managing my time and following up on assignments. For example, I'd often find interesting private companies and do the initial research but then spend too much time on new leads rather than following up on companies I had already found."

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Flaws & Failures

After the [Teamwork & Leadership](#) and [Strengths & Weaknesses questions](#), the "Flaws and Failures" questions represent the third-most important "fit" category.

With these questions, **less is more**. The more you "explain" a flaw, the more bankers will wonder if you're hiding something.

Not all the questions here apply to everyone, so focus on the ones most relevant to your background and specific weaknesses.

1. Why are your grades so low?

You'll get this question if you have below a 3.5 GPA in the U.S. or below a 2:1 in the U.K. (or the equivalent in other countries). The *only* decent answer is an "improvement story":

"To be honest, I had trouble focusing in my first year of university, and I jumped between several different majors and classes. I also spent too much time on athletics, and my grades suffered.

But ever since I decided on accounting and finance, my grades have improved, and I have a 3.8 overall GPA in the major, with A's in every class after my first year. And I did that while taking a full course load, playing football, and working part-time."

2. Why haven't you taken any accounting or finance classes before? Do you really know the material?

Say that you decided on finance relatively late, so you didn't have time for formal classes. Point to your independent study, certifications, or outside classes to show what you've learned.



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You *could* offer to answer technical questions or take an evaluation, but it's probably not a great idea to offer this upfront because it may sound defensive. Let them ask the technical questions if they want to test your knowledge officially. Here's an example answer:

"I haven't taken formal classes in school because I committed to my Materials Engineering major early, and by the time I became interested in banking, it was too late to switch majors and take more relevant classes.

But I have learned a lot through self-study, books, and several M&A case competitions I participated in.

I'm also studying for Level I of the CFA right now, which requires knowledge of accounting and finance, and I knew enough about valuation to complete several stock pitches for the student investment club."

3. Other candidates for our London office speak 3 – 4 European languages fluently. Why don't you?

Point to your other useful skills, such as your native English ability, expertise in a certain industry, or knowledge of programming language that might be useful for finance. Here's an example:

"I was raised in an academic system where other languages weren't emphasized, so I don't have the linguistic skills of other candidates.

That said, I am a native speaker of English with a lot of writing and editing experience, and I understand that you need native speakers to proofread and edit documents because of all the cross-border deals you do here. So, I feel that my skill set could still be helpful.

Also, I have other skills that many candidates lack; for example, I have a computer science minor, and I know VBA and Python fairly well, which could be useful for automating certain tasks."

4. You've never worked in investment banking before. Why do you think you have skills that are relevant to this industry?

Describe the skills that are required in investment banking and then explain how your previous work experience has given you similar skills:



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"I haven't worked in banking before, but from what I know, you need to work long, stressful hours, use analytical and financial skills, pay great attention to small details, and work with internal teams and clients.

I've developed those skills in my time in corporate law at Wilson Sonsini, where I often worked with technology clients completing M&A deals. To do that, I had to advise them on their best legal options and read through hundreds of pages of documents on short notice.

Also, I took several corporate finance classes in law school and learned independently from online courses and books; I'm confident I can join and add value to your team by assisting with technical and deal process work."

5. You're a liberal arts major. How comfortable are you with math? Can you use Excel?

You can use a similar approach and point out how you've gained or used math and analytical skills outside of your major:

"I am a liberal arts major, but I've used math quite a bit outside of my classes, and I'm comfortable with numbers and Excel.

For example, I served as the Budget Chair for the student film organization I was in, and I helped collect fees from members, fundraise, plan events, and pay expenses; I used Excel to plan and forecast the expenses associated with film projects.

Also, in my strategy internship last year, I had to do market analysis using Excel and 'back into' many numbers based on rough estimates."

6. How committed are you to investment banking?

You've already done a private equity internship, so how do I know you won't just leave and return to private equity in a few years?

You saw the private equity internship as a step in your path into investment banking, and you prefer banking for specific reasons; the internship convinced you *not* to pursue PE.

These reasons could include: 1) Too much time spent monitoring portfolio companies and sourcing deals in PE; 2) Compensation being less correlated with short-term performance; 3) Narrower deal/modeling exposure in PE since most deals die in the early stages.

Here's a sample answer:



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"I used my private equity internship to get deal experience and learn more about modeling and valuation. I found a local firm that needed interns and thought it would be more relevant than other options like wealth management.

I learned a lot, but the internship convinced me not to enter the field. I spent a lot of time monitoring portfolio companies and sourcing deals in PE, but I didn't work on many different types of deals – just buyouts and add-on acquisitions – and most didn't advance far.

I want to work on actual deals rather than monitoring companies and taking quick looks at potential deals and passing, so I prefer banking to private equity."

7. You've had several work experience gaps where you weren't working for 3 – 4 months at a time. What were you doing?

This question is *almost* a "Weakness" one, " but it asks about specific experiences rather than your personality or skill set.

To answer it, pretend you did something constructive in each work experience gap, even if it's a huge stretch. Here's an example:

"Sure. I have a few gaps in my work experience because I sometimes took time off between jobs to do volunteer work, complete certifications, or learn new skills.

To save space, I didn't list all of that under 'Work Experience' on my resume. But, for example, when I quit my job at Deloitte three years ago, I went to Costa Rica to learn surfing and study for Level I of the CFA, which I later passed.

In another gap, I did volunteer work in the Dominican Republic and helped the country recover from a natural disaster, and I did a short internship with a local investor there. So, I've always learned new skills or done work during these gaps."

8. You went to business school in Los Angeles but want to work in investment banking. Why didn't you go to school in or near New York City instead?

With this question, you need a **specific** reason for attending the MBA program you did.

The best reason is that you were working full-time in the area and wanted to continue working during a part-time, weekend, or evening program.



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You could also say you were interested in an industry in the area (e.g., tech for San Francisco or energy for Houston), so you wanted to stay in the region.

Then, assuming that you *do* want to be in a financial center such as NY or London, point out that your long-term goal is to work there, which is why you are making the move now:

“My full-time software sales job before business school was in LA, and I completed a part-time/evening program in the area so I could keep working and apply the knowledge from my MBA program to the job itself.

Also, my school has a good track record of sending students into investment banking and a solid alumni network, so I thought it was a fine choice.

When I finish the program, I want to relocate to New York to work in banking full-time since it’s the center of all deal activity in the U.S. I also have some connections to the region since I grew up on Long Island and still have friends and family there.”

9. The person in the other room has perfect grades from Harvard/Oxford.

Why should I hire you over him?

Point out that it’s the *person* who does the work, not the degree. Also, point out that you had to put in far more effort to win this interview than the other person (if you went to a non-target or non-core school).

You can also point to the relevancy of your work experience or your commitment to *staying in* investment banking, unlike many of the students from these top schools.

That said, be careful with your **tone** in answering this type of question because you don’t want to come across as defensive. Here’s an example:

“You should hire me over him because I’m very motivated, I had to put in a lot more work to make it here, and I’m committed to investment banking for the long term.

Coming from a non-core school, I had to send out over 1,000 cold emails just to win interviews, and I made 5 separate weekend trips to New York – just to win my first internship at a middle-market bank last year.

I was the top-ranked intern in my class and outperformed students at higher-ranked schools because it’s the person who does the work – not the degree.



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So, I can immediately add value to your team, and if you hire me, you know I'll stick around for the long term because my goal is investment banking – I'm not going to join and then quit for private equity in a few years."

10. You completed an investment banking internship but then accepted a full-time role in Financial Planning & Analysis (FP&A) in corporate finance after graduation.

Why? Did you fail to get a return offer from your internship?

If you go from an IB internship to something "lower" in the prestige hierarchy, such as an FP&A job, no banker will believe you did it voluntarily.

Just admit that you failed to get a return offer and took the other role to gain experience, improve your technical skills, and prepare to re-apply to full-time IB roles.

To explain why you did not get a return offer, you can use an "I made too many mistakes initially" story, a "no one received return offers" story, or a "tricky situation that made it difficult to get to know the team" story. Here's an example:

"I did not get a return offer from my internship, so I took the FP&A role to gain full-time work experience, improve my modeling skills, and prepare to apply for banking roles once again.

This happened because of some mistakes I made in the first 1 – 2 weeks of the internship and the fact that they switched my team midway through.

I did not do a great job communicating my work tasks and asking questions about the requirements for research and pitch books, so the full-time Analyst found my first presentations confusing.

I improved after the team raised this as an issue, but they switched me to a different group after a few weeks, so I didn't have enough time to prove myself and win support for a return offer from both groups."

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Recruiting Process

These questions are not difficult, but sometimes, it's tough to strike the **right tone** in your answers.



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For example, if you get a question like “Where else are you recruiting?” you must answer slightly differently depending on your level.

Also, sometimes, it’s tricky to know how much you should tell the interviewer and how much you should leave out.

1. Which other investment banks are you applying to?

You **do** want to name other banks that are about the same “level” (bulge bracket, elite boutique, middle market, regional boutique, etc.).

Name-dropping helps your case by giving you “social proof” and showing the bank that other banks like you. This firm is still your top choice, but you have other options.

Avoid mentioning firms at different levels (if possible), as firms may take it as a sign that you’re not confident about getting an offer in their “tier.” Here’s an example:

“The investment banking division at JP Morgan is my first choice, and I would love the opportunity to work here if I receive an offer.

However, I am also applying to several other large banks, including Morgan Stanley, Bank of America, Barclays, and Citi.”

2. Which groups within investment banking are you most interested in?

With this question, say that you’d be very grateful for the chance to work *anywhere* at this firm, but that if you have the choice, you have a few preferences.

You don’t have to rank your preferences, but you should state that the interviewer’s group is among your top choices.

If you’re at the MBA level, you *need* to tie your preferred group to your pre-MBA work experience. You’re at a disadvantage if you don’t do this since most candidates at this level have an industry focus.

Sample Undergraduate-Level “Good” Answer: *“If I win an offer at JP Morgan, I would be grateful for the chance to work in any group within investment banking. But if I had the choice, I would prefer Leveraged Finance, M&A, or Industrials, as I want broad exposure to M&A and debt deals, and Industrials offers great variety.”*



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Sample MBA-Level “Good” Answer: *“I worked in Microsoft’s business development and corporate finance teams before my MBA, so I would prefer to work in the Technology or TMT team to use my industry knowledge. But I would also be open to other groups if I’m fortunate enough to win an offer here.”*

3. Have you received offers from any other firms? Where are you in the interview process?

If you **have** received an offer elsewhere, mention it because it will instantly double your desirability.

If not, say that you’re still going through interviews with other firms and haven’t finished your final rounds.

If you already went through final rounds at another bank, you *may* want to leave out that detail because you’ll lose some credibility if you don’t know your status yet. Here’s an example:

“I’m going through the initial interviews at Morgan Stanley and Bank of America, and I’m scheduled for final-round interviews at Citi and Barclays next week.”

4. You applied to our investment banking rotational program last year.

Why didn’t you win an offer, and what has changed since then?

Banks do not necessarily track this information for all candidates, but an *individual interviewer* might remember you.

Say that you knew less about accounting/finance, had less work experience, or had a lower GPA, and then explain your improvements since then. Here’s an example:

“Sure. I don’t know exactly why I didn’t win an offer, but I believe it’s because I knew less about accounting and finance than other candidates. My interviewers thought I was a good fit but mentioned that I had trouble with the more difficult technical questions.

Since then, I’ve completed a boutique investment banking internship at a local firm and taken additional accounting and finance classes, and I feel more confident in my technical knowledge.”

5. Do you have any questions for me? [at the end of the interview]



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You could ask about the interviewer's background, what surprised them the most, the types of deals the bank is working on, or the qualities that made previous interns successful.

Use common sense and do **not** ask inappropriate questions (e.g., their compensation) or questions with easy-to-find answers (e.g., an average day in the life of a banker).

If you've already been through multiple interviews, you don't "need" to ask yet another question at the end of your 10th interview. Just explain how you've already been through 9 interviews and have no further questions. Here are a few examples:

"Sure. Can you tell me about your background and how you decided to join this group?"

"Sure. I understand what interns in your team do, but what qualities have made interns successful in the past? I'm especially interested in parts of the job that people rarely discuss."

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Resume/CV

These questions mostly test if you understand what you have written about on your resume or CV. If you've exaggerated or outright lied about something, it *will* come back to haunt you in interviews (so don't do it).

You can answer many of these questions by re-using [your Success, Leadership, and Failure stories](#), which is why it's so important to craft those "short stories" first.

1. What are the three most impressive entries on your resume?

This question should be easy because you can answer it with your three short stories.

You could spin your "Failure" story as a non-failure or make it sound less serious, which works if you had an extremely challenging goal, such as starting a business while in university.

You could also use a different experience and describe it in 1 – 2 sentences instead. Here's an example:

"My three most impressive experiences are my strategy and finance internship at IBM, my math tutoring business in university, and my Treasury internship at a local tech startup."

At IBM, I helped analyze thousands of financial transactions, found the most time-consuming processes, and suggested ways to automate them, which saved hundreds of hours per year."



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In my second year of university, I started a math tutoring business, won dozens of clients, and hired a few coaches; I shut it down because I wanted to focus on school and gain more finance experience.

Finally, in my Treasury internship, I helped the firm comply with its Debt covenants by working with different departments to move around Cash right before the reporting deadline, which saved the company thousands in fees and interest.”

2. What did you learn in your most recent internship at [Firm Name]?

Hopefully, the interviewer is asking about an entry that matches one of your short stories.

If not, think about **the skill set overlap** between this recent internship and investment banking.

You could discuss pitch books or marketing materials you worked on, deals or clients you worked with, market/industry research, or even helping the full-timers with emergency tasks or “random” work that shows how well you function under pressure. Here’s an example:

“Sure. In my recent internship at a real estate brokerage boutique in my area, I researched new properties in the market and demographic trends to estimate potential pricing based on Cap Rates (yields) for comparable properties and deals.

I spent a lot of time combing through data, finding recent comp sales in databases, and touring properties to see how their ‘in-person’ values might differ from market norms.

We used this to build quick valuations for multifamily and office properties and figure out which ones might be appealing to different types of institutional buyers, and I learned about property valuation and narrowing lists of potential buyers in the process.”

3. Why did you quit your job in the [Company Name] [Group Name] team after you were promoted twice?

This answer should come directly from your main “story” – the 300-word version where you explain your career transitions and why you want to move into investment banking.

Say that you did well in the role, you liked your team, and things were going well, but your career goals changed, so you decided to move elsewhere. Here’s an example:

“Sure. I enjoyed my time at IBM, liked my team, and did well there as I worked all over the U.S. and Europe in corporate finance.



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I left the job because I wanted to work on M&A deals instead of doing the monthly and quarterly reporting common in corporate finance.

I became very interested when IBM acquired a smaller startup, DataStax, to expand its presence in the cloud database market. I liked the due diligence and financial analysis I assisted with in that deal and became more interested in M&A over time.

Moving to corporate development at IBM wasn't an option, so I decided to join KPMG, work in Transaction Advisory Services there, and then move into investment banking."

4. Why did you attend your university?

The answer to this question should come directly from your main "story," so you should not need to prepare much here.

You probably won't get this question if you went to an Ivy League or equivalent school, but you may get it if you're at a non-target or another school the interviewers are unfamiliar with.

Cite the academics, the generous scholarship you received, the location, or almost anything else to explain your choice:

"Sure. I went to Purdue because I'm from Indiana originally, and I received a generous scholarship there that covered 90% of my tuition and living expenses.

It has good engineering and business programs, and I was interested in both. I also liked all the sports teams since I follow a lot of college football and basketball.

I won admission to a few out-of-state universities that were higher in the rankings, but they would have been much more expensive, and I wanted to graduate with as little debt as possible."

5. Why did you attend an MBA program after you already had 2-3 years of work experience?

Couldn't you move into banking directly?

If your career is "too different" (e.g., marketing), it is extremely difficult to network into investment banking after working for a few years.

Even if you've done something closely related, such as Big 4 advisory, it gets more difficult the longer you wait.



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You can also say that you received feedback from bankers indicating that you'd need an MBA to make the switch. Here's an example:

"I tried doing that for about 6 months but didn't get much interest in my candidacy. I figured my advisory experience at Ernst & Young and the finance and business development work I did at my startup would help me.

But 90% of the bankers I spoke with said I would be perceived as a 'career changer' candidate since I had started my own company.

Almost everyone recommended that I complete a top MBA program to transition into investment banking, so I took their advice."

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Understanding Banking

"Understanding Banking" questions include:

- What bankers do and how they advise on M&A and capital markets deals.
- What different groups, such as Leveraged Finance and M&A, do.
- How the process for an initial public offering (IPO) or acquisition works.
- How you would summarize recent stock market and M&A activity.

If you've done enough research to win interviews in the first place, you should know these topics like the back of your hand.

1. How do companies select the investment banks and bankers they work with?

Companies usually select banks based on **relationships** developed over the long term, but sometimes, it's more random and happens because of a pitch or "bake-off" right before the deal process begins (banks compete to win the business).

The selection depends on the team's comfort with each bank, the banks' track records, and their key recommendations. Here's an example answer:



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“Companies select banks based on the long-term relationships they’ve developed, the banks’ track records, and the pitches the banks make.

Often, bankers start speaking with companies long before a deal takes place and advise them informally over the years, leading to future transactions.

If the bank is known for something specific, such as selling tech companies for high multiples, that might also factor into the company’s decision.

Finally, each bank’s pitch in a ‘bake-off’ meeting also factors in: Companies pick the bankers they’re most comfortable with and the ones that give the best recommendations.”

2. Let’s say I’m working on an Initial Public Offering (IPO) for a client. Can you briefly describe what I would do?

If you want the full details, please see the [IPO process](#) and [ECM](#) articles on M&I. Here’s a concise summary:

“In an IPO, you aim to get the client a good valuation, recruit solid institutional investors, and support the client’s share price once it goes public.

First, you meet the client and gather financial, industry, and customer information.

Then, you meet with other bankers and lawyers to draft the IPO registration statement, called the ‘S-1’ in the U.S., which markets the company to investors.

You receive comments from the SEC and revise the document until it’s acceptable.

Then, you spend a few weeks on a ‘roadshow’ where you pitch the company to institutional investors. You get pricing indications at the end, you sell shares to the investors at that ‘IPO price,’ and then the company begins trading on a stock exchange.

The hardest part of the process is balancing the client’s expectations with the investors’ and ensuring that the initial share price is neither “too high” nor “too low” because the best outcome is a modest gain on the first day of trading.”

3. Walk me through the process of a typical sell-side M&A deal.

Again, we have an article on [M&A investment banking](#) if you want more detail, but here’s the short version:



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“In a sell-side M&A deal, the bank markets the company to potential buyers and helps negotiate a deal for the best price and terms possible.

The bankers start by meeting the company, creating initial marketing materials like the Executive Summary and Offering Memorandum (OM), and deciding on potential buyers.

Then, they send the Executive Summary to potential buyers to gauge interest, and they respond to follow-up requests for more information.

Next, they narrow the list of potential buyers by setting a bid deadline and requiring written Indications of Interest (IOIs) from buyers. Bankers select certain bidders to advance, continue to send them information, and narrow the list.

Eventually, they pick the winner, negotiate the Purchase Agreement, and announce the deal. Bankers try to maximize the client's price, but they also add value by negotiating the other terms and winning competing offers.”

4. Walk me through the process of a typical buy-side M&A deal.

This one is like the process above, but now you *minimize* the price so your client pays less. The steps above are reversed because you approach **potential sellers** rather than buyers:

“In a buy-side M&A deal, the bank helps the client select the best acquisition target, minimizes the price it pays, and gets it the best deal terms possible.

First, the bankers spend time doing upfront research on dozens or hundreds of potential acquisition targets based on what the client wants to buy.

Next, they narrow the list and decide which companies to approach; they conduct meetings with interested parties and gauge each one's receptiveness.

Then, they narrow this list further and conduct more in-depth due diligence on the most likely sellers. They use the companies' financial information to value the target companies and propose offer prices.

Finally, the bankers negotiate the price and key terms of the Purchase Agreement and announce the transaction.

Bankers add value in this process by minimizing the price, finding potential targets, and getting the best terms possible.”



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5. Walk me through a debt issuance deal.

This one depends on whether you're selling the debt to investors (common for Senior Debt, Subordinated, and Mezzanine issuances) or your bank is keeping the debt on its Balance Sheet.

In the walkthrough below, we'll assume a "generic" process and note the possible differences (see the [full DCM article](#) for more):

"The process of raising debt is similar to the process of raising equity, but your goals are different because you want to get the lowest interest rates and the least restrictive covenants and other deal terms for the client.

First, you meet with the client and gather basic financial and market information.

Next, you work closely with DCM or Leveraged Finance to develop a credit model for the company; you analyze the company's credit stats and ratios in different cases, focusing on the more pessimistic ones, to assess the most appropriate terms.

Then, you create an investor memo describing the issuance and "selling" the company to potential investors.

If you're not syndicating the debt, this memo would be for the bank's internal credit committee to win approval for the deal.

If you syndicate the debt, you would contact potential investors and win commitments to purchase the entire issuance."

6. Can you describe a Leveraged Buyout (LBO) and how the process works?

Please see the [LBO technical question sections](#) for the model walkthrough and math; this answer describes the deal process.

A leveraged buyout is similar to a sell-side M&A deal since the bank helps a company sell itself; the key difference is that the potential buyers are private equity firms:

"In an LBO, a private equity firm uses debt and equity to acquire a company, operates it for several years, and then sells it to realize a return.

Like a sell-side M&A deal, the bank advising the company still aims for the best price and deal terms.



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First, the bank meets with the company, creates marketing materials like the Confidential Information Memorandum (CIM) and Executive Summary, and makes a list of PE firms to approach.

Then, the bankers send out the materials to gauge interest, respond to follow-up requests, and send more information.

The bank narrows the list of potential buyers by setting a bid deadline and requiring Indications of Interest, and sometimes there are multiple rounds of bids.

After the bank and company pick the winner, they negotiate the terms of the deal. The bank could potentially offer debt financing from its Leveraged Finance team to support the deal as well, but this varies by bank, region, and deal type.”

7. What’s in a pitch book?

In a shocking plot twist, we also happen to have a detailed article on [IB pitch books](#), which you should review for many examples.

Answering this question *concisely* is tricky because there are many different types of pitch books, so we recommend focusing on the *common elements* in all of them:

“The point of a pitch book is to convince a company to hire your bank as an adviser on an M&A deal, equity or debt issuance, or another transaction.

First, the bank presents its “credentials” – its recent track record and similar deals it has worked on – to prove its expertise.

Second, the bank summarizes the company’s options and its key recommendations.

Third, the bank presents a valuation of the company and related financial models; in financing deals, the bank might show the company’s capital structure before and after the deal and information about the credit stats.

Next, the bank shows potential acquisition targets (for buy-side M&A deals) or potential buyers (for sell-side M&A deals)

The bank concludes by summarizing everything, giving its top recommendations, and outlining the timing of a potential deal.”

8. Can you tell me about the different groups at an investment bank?



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The broad categories are “[industry groups](#)” ([Healthcare](#), [Consumer/Retail](#), [Technology](#), etc.) and “[product groups](#)” ([Mergers & Acquisitions](#), [Leveraged Finance](#), [Equity Capital Markets](#), etc.).

Industry groups work with companies in only one industry, but they work on multiple deal types, while product groups advise on only one deal type but across all industries.

Some groups are also more or less technical, have better or worse hours, and offer better or worse exit opportunities, but **you should not bring up these points** because you don’t want to seem motivated solely by potential exits. Here’s a sample answer:

“There are industry groups and product groups at most investment banks. Industry groups work within only one industry, such as Healthcare, Retail, or Energy, but they work on all deal types within that industry; they focus on relationship development with clients and use their industry knowledge to advance deals.

Product groups include M&A, Equity and Debt Capital Markets, and Leveraged Finance. Each group executes only one deal type, such as acquisitions or debt financings, but they do so across all industries.

They become experts in the technical details behind deal execution.”

9. Let’s say you become an investment banker, and you’re hired as the financial advisor for a company to help it expand its business.

How would you approach this task, and how would you add value as an advisor?

There isn’t a “framework” to answer this question, so here’s the sample answer:

“First, I would ask the company for its specific expansion goals – a certain revenue or profit target, a new geography, or a new product, for example.

Then, I would assess the company’s financial and market profile and determine if it makes the most sense to acquire other companies, raise capital, set up partnerships, or pursue another strategy, such as organic growth.

For example, if the company’s leverage ratio is very high and it has almost no cash, acquisitions make less sense than partnerships or raising equity to fund organic expansion.

As a banker, I would add value by introducing the management to potential partners and acquisition targets, negotiating deals, and managing the process to get the best outcome.”



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10. A client approaches you and asks whether it should go public or sell to another company. How would you help the management team think through this decision?

You should present the **trade-offs** of both strategies to the company, such as the potentially faster process and “clean break” in an M&A deal and the slower/more time-consuming process but potentially higher long-term value in an IPO.

Again, it’s best to read and understand the sample answer here:

“I would present the trade-offs of both options to the client and explain that an M&A deal offers a ‘clean break’ and sometimes a faster/easier process, but the client will give up most of its control and won’t participate much in future upside. Many deals also fail.

In an IPO, the client sells only a minority stake, so shareholders and employees get some liquidity, but the company keeps operating as a standalone entity and retains control.

But IPOs are time-consuming and don’t necessarily lead to higher prices or faster growth.

The best option depends on whether the team wants to stay with the company for the long term and how much potential the business has – if the team is in it for the long haul, and the potential is very high, an IPO often makes more sense.

If the team does not want to stay, or the business appears to be nearing its ceiling, then an M&A deal makes more sense.”

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“Why Banking?” and “Why Our Firm?”

These questions are not that important because you should have already answered them in your “story.”

However, interviewers could still ask for slight variations to confirm your motivations and cross-check your responses.

(Also, note that the basic “Why investment banking?” question is [in the first section.](#))

1. What are your long-term plans? Where do you see yourself in 5 – 10 years, and are you committed to investment banking?



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At the Associate level and above (MBA recruiting), the only acceptable answer is: *“Yes, I am 100% committed, and I plan for a long-term career in banking.”*

You can be a bit more open-ended at the Analyst level (i.e., undergrads and recent grads with only a few years of work experience).

For example, you can say that you want to work on deals in Industry X due to your previous work/academic experience and plan to do so over the next 5 – 10 years. After that, you want to continue in a finance job related to Industry X, but you’re not sure where that will be yet.

2. You said you want to work at our firm to gain exposure to bigger, more complex deals. But what if an even bigger bank comes calling next year – would you move again?

This one will come up if you’re working at a regional boutique and you’re interviewing with a middle-market bank, elite boutique, or a slightly larger bank.

To answer this, you should say that this bank offers the ideal mix of deal size/complexity and client interaction. Yes, a larger bank would offer bigger and more complex deals, but you also value the team size and client interactions, and you prefer this firm because of the balance it offers.

3. Why do you prefer the [Industry Name] group to other industry groups at our firm?

You could use almost anything to explain your interest, from the professions of your family and friends to previous internships to student activities, classes, and bank-sponsored competitions.

For example, to explain your interest in the real estate sector, you can point out that one family member operates properties or worked as a broker, and you interned at a property management company and learned the fundamentals from that. But you’re interested in working on larger deals involving real estate-related companies rather than managing individual properties.

We don’t necessarily recommend citing “industry fundamentals” unless they ask you about them; it sounds weird to say that you’re interested in real estate investment banking because real estate is an inflation hedge, for example (in the story above).

4. Why are you moving from a larger bank to a smaller bank? Did you not receive a return offer at the larger bank?



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If you did *not* get a return offer, please refer to [the Flaws & Failures section](#), own up to it, and explain how you've improved over that previous version of yourself.

If you are legitimately moving to a smaller bank (e.g., bulge bracket to elite boutique) despite receiving an offer at the large bank, you could point to the advantages of independent firms over the large banks:

"I received a return offer at Morgan Stanley, but I'm more interested in Lazard because I'd be able to focus on M&A and Restructuring deals, and I would get more client exposure because of the smaller team sizes.

Also, I think I'm a better fit for your culture based on the bankers I've met so far.

Finally, I'm interested in a long-term career in banking, and your firm is much better for that since you offer more independence and more interesting work."

5. Why do you want to work in M&A rather than an industry group?

Link this to your interest in a specific M&A deal or an M&A case competition and say that you want to specialize in deal execution rather than a specific industry.

Do **NOT** cite "exit opportunities" or the ease of moving into private equity. Here's an example:

"Sure. Just to clarify, I'd be open to working in any investment banking team if I'm fortunate enough to win an offer at your firm.

But if I could pick, I would choose M&A because of my interest in mergers and acquisitions and the bank-sponsored M&A case competitions I've entered in the past.

I also enjoy the technical analysis of deals and deal mechanics more than learning a single industry in-depth.

The Technology and Healthcare teams would also be great, but I would prefer M&A if I had the choice."

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"Outside the Box" Questions

These questions are tricky because you can't necessarily "prepare" for them.



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Interviewers could throw many random questions at you; all you can do is **be aware** of the topics they might ask about.

Many of these questions are also forms of “the airport test.” If a banker gets stuck with you in an airport for the day, could they get along with you and stay entertained? Or would they be tempted to read a book, start a new streaming series, or jump out the window?

1. Tell me something interesting about you that is NOT listed on your resume.

One strategy here is to pick **an experience from when you were a young child.**

You probably have a lot of university-level experience on your resume, but you’re less likely to include items from high school/secondary school, middle school, or elementary school.

You can use almost anything, from travel to family to sports and activities. Just use common sense and don’t say anything about your OnlyFans “side hustle” or a stint as an AI/crypto “influencer.” Here’s an example:

“Sure. When I was in elementary school, I participated in a program where we traveled around the U.S. and lived in all 50 states over 5 years.

We spent just over one month in each state and took classes there, played sports, did volunteer activities, and met people from all over the country.

Our teachers also changed as we moved to new areas, so I learned a lot and later studied abroad in Brazil partially because of this experience.”

2. You have \$1 million, but you are NOT allowed to invest it or use it to make more money.

How would you spend the money?

Answer this question by admitting that you’d spend some money on a high-end vacation, a nice car, or another luxury good you’ve always wanted.

You’d spend the rest on something related to your hobbies and interests – ideally, something that also benefits others. Here’s an example:

“First, I’d use a small portion of it on a vacation to the Galapagos Islands. I might also use some money on a nicer apartment or home.



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Then, I'd use the remaining amount to open a community gym in my area. I've practiced weightlifting for years, and I think all kids should learn about physical fitness early.

Where I grew up, they didn't have the chance to do that because it's a rural area without any nearby gyms."

3. What's your "personal Beta"?

"Beta" in the [Capital Asset Pricing Model \(CAPM\)](#) measures a stock's returns relative to the returns of the entire market.

If the stock's Beta is 1.0, it increases by 10% when the market increases by 10%.

If the stock's Beta is 2.0, it falls by 20% when the market falls by 10% but rises by 20% when the market rises by 10%.

You should say that your "Beta" is above 1.0 but not too much above it. You're ambitious, and you try more things than the average person, but you don't take inordinate risks:

"My 'personal Beta' is around 1.5. I take more risks than the average person so I can achieve more, but I'm not enough of a risk-taker to quit everything and do something completely random, like starting an adventure tourism company in Africa.

I'm happy to accept the risk if an internship or job doesn't go as planned, and I don't like to 'play it safe' with those. But I've balanced that by working at larger, well-established companies."

4. In 30 years, your name turns up on the front page of a major newspaper.

What would the headline be, and what would the story be about?

With this question, you can show more "banker-like" traits such as work ethic and analytical skills – but you shouldn't take it *too* seriously.

So, your headline might be about starting a company, becoming a best-selling author, curing a disease, or funding a mission to another planet.

Combine ambition and novelty without going too far into "sci-fi" territory (e.g., **don't** say that you will discover faster-than-light travel, as this is implausible within 30 years):



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"The headline would probably be: 'First Manned Mission to Jupiter Returns Intact.' The story would be about how I funded a mission to go beyond the asteroid belt in our solar system and study the gas giants.

I've always been interested in space exploration and the possibility of mining asteroids, moons, and other planets, so if I do well over the next 15 – 20 years, I might fund this type of mission.

It takes at least a few years to reach Jupiter at maximum rocket speeds, so this entire mission would probably take at least a decade, if not longer."

5. If you were an animal, which one would you be?

Don't take this question too seriously; use it as a chance to show your personality and make a light-hearted comment.

It's fine if you can tie in the qualities that bankers are looking for, but don't try too hard:

"I love to swim, and I also like group activities, so I would probably be a dolphin. Also, dolphins never really sleep – at least one side of their brain is always awake – and that might be a useful skill for this job!"

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